paper, Achrekar Sir was seriously unhappy with what I had done and told me off for consenting to have runs added to my personal tally when I hadn't scored them. I acknowledged my mistake and promised never to allow such a thing to happen again.

The first-match jinx continued in my first season for the Mumbai Under-15 team in Pune in 1985. I was only twelve then and travelled to Pune with just 95 rupees in my pocket. This was to be supplemented with the little allowance we were given during the tour, which lasted more than a week. In my only match for Mumbai I was run out. I was batting with someone from my school who was older than me and because he was a faster runner he completed the runs quicker and pushed for a third run that was not on. As a result I was run out and I returned to the pavilion with tears in my eyes. Thoughtfully, two veteran Mumbai cricketers, Milind Rege and Vasu Paranjpe, consoled me, saying the run just wasn't there and I shouldn't have been called to go for it.

It rained a lot in Pune in the next few days and as it turned out this was my only innings. As a result I was not picked for the West Zone Under-15 team and was upset because a few of my team-mates who had not played a single ball had been chosen ahead of me. To add to my distress, I ran out of money because I spent it all on snacks and fast food – and arrived at Dadar station with no fare for the bus home. I had to walk back to Shivaji Park to my uncle's carrying two big bags and cried all the way. My aunt was very concerned when she saw me and asked what the matter was. I did not tell her that I hadn't been selected for the West Zone team and all I said was I was not feeling too well.

My first earnings from cricket

Playing for my school regularly helped me learn the art of scoring big runs and batting for a long time. During school holidays I played practice matches for my club almost every day. In fact, in my first year at Shardashram I played fifty-five practice matches during the summer break of sixty days. My summer sessions used to start at 7.30 a.m. and I'd bat for two hours, split into five net sessions. All of these sessions were rigorous and required intense concentration. After the morning session, I would go straight into the practice match, which would end at 4.30 p.m., then my evening session would start at 5 p.m., after only a thirty-minute break. During the break Sir would often give me some